Sticky Sesame Tofu

Sticky, savory sesame tofu with a sweet and tangy sauce. Crispy tofu tossed in the best takeout-style sesame sauce. Ready in under an hour!

Ingredients

Crispy Tofu

- ☐ 1 (14 or 16 oz) block firm or extra-firm tofu
- ☐ 1 tablespoon neutral vegetable oil
- ☐ 1/2 teaspoon salt
- ☐ 1/2 teaspoon onion powder
- ☐ 1/2 teaspoon garlic powder
- ☐ black pepper to preference
- ☐ 2 tablespoons cornstarch or potato starch

Sesame Sauce

- ☐ 3 tablespoons soy sauce
- ☐ 2 tablespoons ketchup
- ☐ 3 tablespoons brown sugar
- ☐ 2 tablespoons rice vinegar
- ☐ 2 teaspoons toasted sesame oil
- ☐ 2 teaspoons cornstarch
- ☐ 1 tablespoon neutral vegetable oil
- ☐ 1 tablespoon minced garlic
- ☐ 1 green onion chopped, whites and greens separated
- ☐ 2 tablespoons toasted sesame seeds
- ☐ 1 teaspoons szechuan pepper
- ☐ 1 teaspoons chinese five spice

Instructions

Make the Crispy Tofu

- Drain the block of tofu and use your favorite method to press out the excess moisture for at least 15 minutes. I like to use my tofu press.
- Cut the tofu into cubes or tear it into bite-sized pieces and add them to a bowl.
- Drizzle vegetable oil over the tofu pieces. Sprinkle on salt, onion powder, garlic powder, and black pepper (to preference). Toss to evenly coat.

The tofu can be a bit delicate, so a flexible rubber spatula can be helpful to gently toss without the tofu crumbling too much. Alternatively, if you have a container with a lid, you can gently shake to coat.

- Sprinkle the cornstarch (or potato starch) over the seasoned tofu. Again, gently toss or shake to coat.

Air Fryer Instructions for Crispy Tofu

- If needed, spray or brush the bottom of your air fryer basket with oil to help prevent sticking (I usually skip this step because mine is nonstick).
- Transfer the tofu pieces into the basket of your air fryer. (You can spray or lightly brush the bottom of the basket with oil if it isn't nonstick.) It's best if you can keep the pieces in one layer with just a little bit of space in between them (so they don't stick together), but it's okay if they overlap a little.
- Air fry for 18-20 minutes at 400°F, or until golden brown and crispy. Give the air fryer basket a shake at around the 8 minute mark. Then give it another shake after 5 more minutes. This will help the tofu to brown and crisp evenly.
- **An important note:** Each model of air fryer will work a little differently. The first time you make this recipe, I recommend checking on the tofu periodically as it cooks, just to make sure it doesn't overly brown. The tofu may also cook a little faster if you pressed it longer. More excess moisture = longer cook time. Feel free to add extra cook time (1-2 minutes at a time) to achieve the perfect level of crispiness.

Make the Sesame Tofu

- In a small bowl or measuring cup, whisk together soy sauce, ketchup, brown sugar, rice vinegar, toasted sesame oil, szechuan pepper, five spice and cornstarch.
- Add vegetable oil to a skillet. Add the minced garlic and the white parts of the green onions *before* turning on the heat. (This will help to prevent the garlic from burning.)
- Place the pan over medium heat. Once it begins to sizzle, sauté for 2-3 minutes, or until the whites of the green onions are turning translucent and the mixture is very fragrant.
- Give the sauce mixture another whisk to redistribute the cornstarch, then pour the mixture into the pan with the scallions and garlic. It should begin to simmer almost immediately. Stir constantly for 1-2 minutes, and the sauce should thicken up.
- Add the crispy tofu, the green parts of the scallions, and the toasted sesame seeds. Toss to coat, and serve immediately.